



Palawan, 27 to 31 Dec: compare our options

4 ways to spend the 4 days between Manila and Boracay New Year's Eve, each scored on real review data. The options are shown with their evidence, trade-offs, seats and weighted scores so we can decide together.



SAT 26 DEC

Sydney ✈️ Manila

Lands 6:05pm • Poblacion night out 🎉

BOOKED



SUN 27 DEC

Manila ✈️ Puerto Princesa

3:30 → 4:55pm

Non-refundable • ~A\$93 each

BOOKED



THU 31 DEC

El Nido (Lio) ✈️ Caticlan

2:45 → 3:50pm • Boracay NYE

🕒 At Lio airport by 1:15pm

BOOKED

👁️ The 4 options at a glance

Tap one to jump to its card. Prices are A\$ per person. 📊 = weighted evidence score out of 50 (how we scored).

NEW

UNPROVEN

1 • Port Barton → El Nido

3-day boat trip, beach tents

~**A\$700–750** each



21/50



THE CLASSIC

2 • Coron → El Nido

Famous boat trip via Clark

~**A\$850–1,050** each



43/50



STAY IN EL NIDO

3 • Stay in El Nido

Surf, day boat, hostels

~**A\$450–700** each



38/50

NEW

NEW OPERATOR

A • Yohak Linapacan

Glamping, new operator

~**A\$900–950** each



22/50

Where each option goes

All four routes with their costs. Open the web page for the interactive map with photos.



1 • Port Barton → El Nido

PPS → Port Barton → 3 days → El Nido
~A\$700-750

★ 2 • Coron → El Nido

Clark → Coron → 3 days → El Nido
~A\$850-1,050

3 • Stay in El Nido

PPS → El Nido → Nacpan → day trip
~A\$450-700

A • Yohak Linapacan

El Nido → Linapacan → Parada → BACK
~A\$900-950

All options end with Lio → Boracay on 31 Dec

Legend:
 - - - Flight
 — Road
 Boat

Grey dashed = already-booked flights

Dashed pin border = approximate spot



The options, one by one

Every dot now comes from a rule (see [How we scored](#)) and the key number behind it is shown under it. More dots is better; for Logistics, more dots = safer.

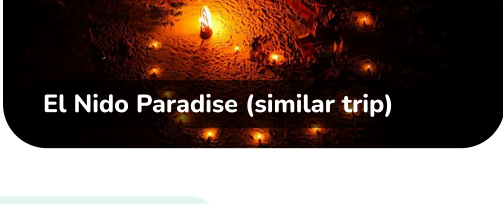
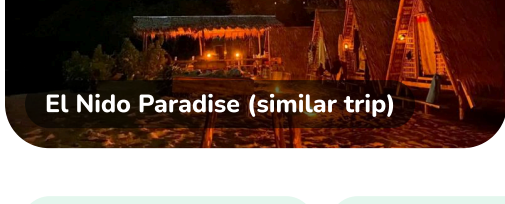
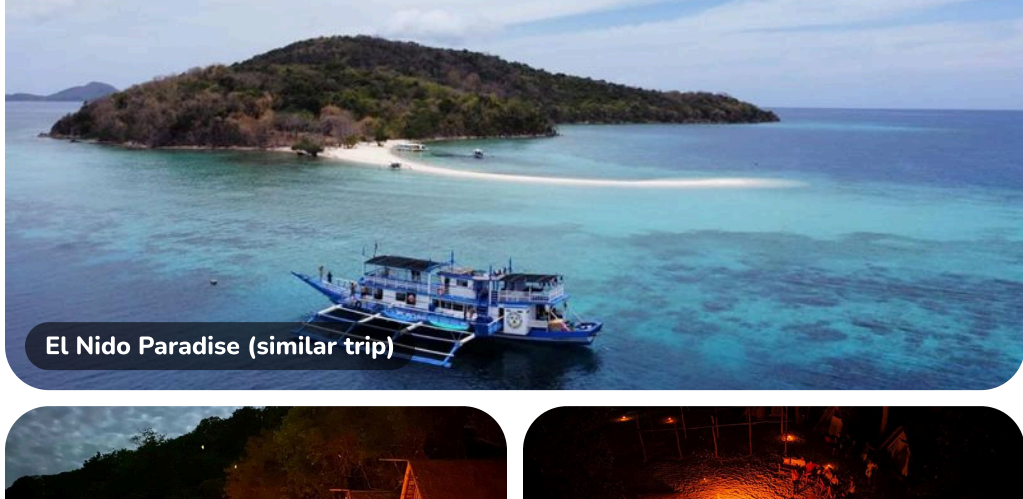
NEW **NEW ROUTE**

1

Port Barton → El Nido boat trip

El Nido Paradise · 3-day expedition

~A\$700–750 A\$ per person, all in



✓ **Keeps all flights**

☀️ **Calmer west coast in Dec**

17 **28 Dec shown available**

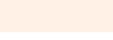
NEW **New route: 0 reviews, group unproven**



Seats booked so far: 2 of 18 booked online

Online bookings only; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show.

27 **SUN**



Land PPS, van to Port Barton

~3–3.5h · arrive ~8:30–9pm · hotel

28 **MON**



Boat trip starts

Port Barton turtles

29 **TUE**



Long Beach + Malampaya Sound

Beach-camp tents

30 **WED**



South Bacuit → El Nido

Arrive ~4:30pm · hotel

31 **THU**



Free morning

Lio airport by 1:15pm

💰 Tour ₱18,900 (~A\$423) + van ~A\$100 + rooms ~A\$170

🏕️ Tents with bedding, showers and toilets

👥 Up to 18 guests

17 **One of only 4 December departures (other dates full)**

★ Tripadvisor 4.9 from 1,317 reviews; Google 4.8 from ~2,097; Travelers' Choice 2026. This route: 0 reviews (new)

The catch: zero reviews of this route and no proof of a lively group yet (it launches Oct 2026), and it's tents. It fits the booked flights, but its top-criteria evidence is not yet established.



Evidence score

21/50

Weighted: reviews and social count x3 · unweighted 17/30



Social x3



1/5 ticks on its own evidence: a shared group (up to 18). No reviews, so the group is unproven. (The Coron proxy would tick 5/5, but proxies are not scored.)



Scenery



3 days along the remote west coast, but the route is new with no guest reviews



Sleep



Beach tents with mats and bedding; no reviews of these camps yet



Logistics (safer)



1 flag: new route. Flights kept, sheltered west coast, ends a day before the flight



Review strength x3



0 reviews of this route (it launches Oct 2026). Operator-wide Tripadvisor 4.9 from 1,317 reviews; Google 4.8 from ~2,097; Travelers' Choice 2026 shown, not counted



Value



~A\$725 midpoint scores 4, +1 because all 3 boat days are catered



The evidence

checked 28 Sep 2026

This route is new (it launches this October), so there are **no reviews of it yet**, and it is scored only on that. Everything under the PROXY label comes from the same operator's Coron route (the same boats and crews since 2015). It is shown for context and **is not scored**.



This route



0

reviews

Operator product page: "There are no reviews yet"



Route videos

0

found

No YouTube videos of the Port Barton route yet



Tripadvisor



4.9

1,317 reviews

Operator-wide. From a search snippet, because Tripadvisor blocks us



Google Maps



4.8

~2,097 reviews

Operator-wide

PROXY

Coron route data (same operator, same boats and crews)



Operator site



5.00

17 reviews

Coron → El Nido product (2017 to Nov 2024)



Operator site



4.96

27 reviews

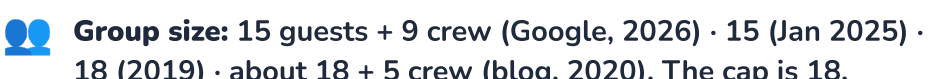
El Nido → Coron product (2016 to Jan 2025)



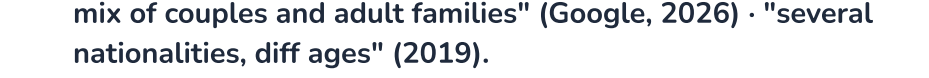
Praise the group, people or vibe



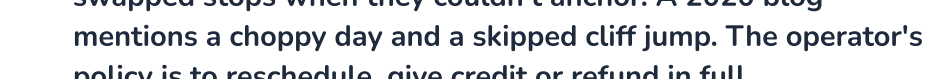
Say quiet, too young or too old



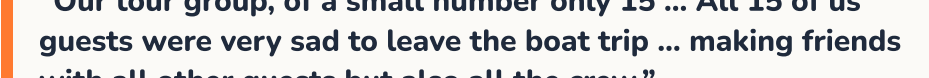
Praise the crew or guide



Sleep or facility complaints



Weather cancellations reported



Group size: 15 guests + 9 crew (Google, 2026) · 15 (Jan 2025) · 18 (2019) · about 18 + 5 crew (blog, 2020). The cap is 18.



Age mix: "quite mixed in age and nationality" (Tripadvisor) · "a mix of couples and adult families" (Google, 2026) · "several nationalities, diff ages" (2019).



Weather: no cancellations in the reviews. One 2018 trip swapped stops when they couldn't anchor. A 2020 blog mentions a choppy day and a skipped cliff jump. The operator's policy is to reschedule, give credit or refund in full.

"Our tour group, of a small number only 15 ... All 15 of us guests were very sad to leave the boat trip ... making friends with all other guests but also all the crew."
Isabel C., operator site (El Nido → Coron), 26 Jan 2025

"There was a good mix of nationalities and ages on the boat. A few couples, a few groups of friends, solo travellers and a mother and son."
Irish on the Run blog (Coron route), Apr 2020



See the real website



Trip schedule



Private van ₱9,100/van



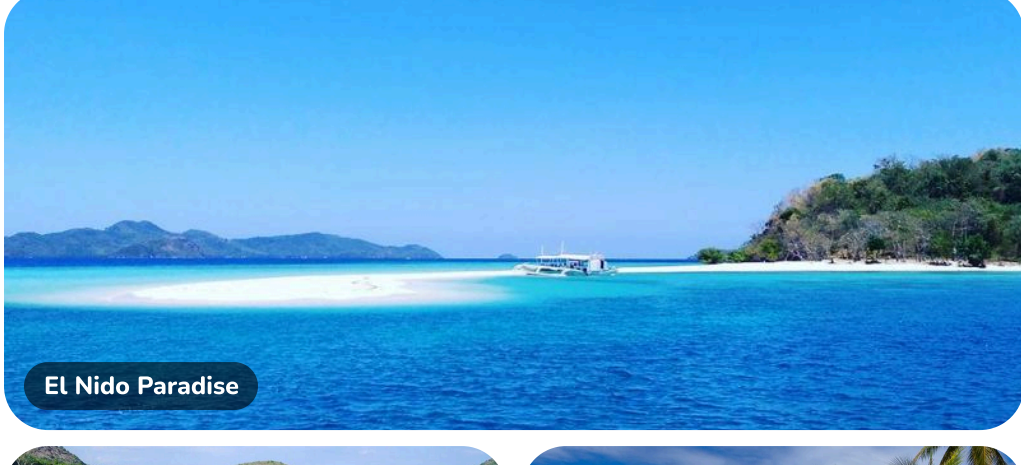
Checked: no El Nido round trip fits

El Nido Paradise's 2-day El Nido Linapacan loop has no December dates open; private trips can loop but are not social; Tao's trips on these dates are 4 to 6 days; the only new shared loop (We Are Juan, 29 to 30 Dec, ₱14,000) has 0 reviews and 0 bookings.

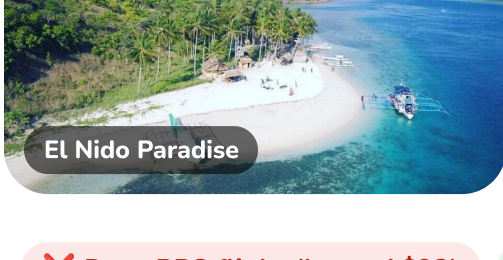
Coron → El Nido boat trip

Fly Clark → Coron · El Nido Paradise flagship

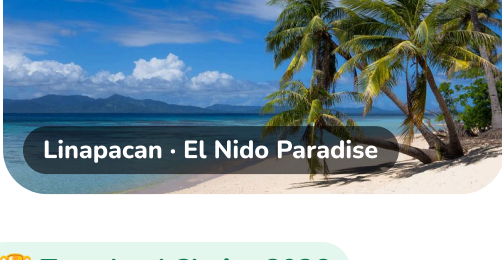
~A\$850–1,050 A\$ per person, all in



El Nido Paradise



El Nido Paradise



Linapacan · El Nido Paradise

✗ Drop PPS flight (lose ~A\$93)

🏆 Travelers' Choice 2026

👤 Liveliest groups

🛥 Seats unconfirmed



Seats booked so far: 13 of 32 booked online

Online bookings only; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show.

27 SUN



Manila → Clark → Coron

Car 9am · Cebgo 1:15pm Clark → Coron (backup PAL Express 2:15pm) · travel day ↓

28 MON



Boat trip starts

Culion

29 TUE



Ditaytayan sandbar

Linapacan · nipa huts

30 WED



Arrive El Nido

~5pm

31 THU



Free morning

Lio airport by 1:15pm



Tour ₱21,900 (~A\$490) + flights + hotels



Beach nipa huts



Remote scenery through Culion and Linapacan



Early start after the Manila night out



Tripadvisor 4.9 from 1,317 reviews; Google 4.8 from ~2,097;

Travelers' Choice 2026



The catch: Trade-offs: give up the booked PPS flight (~A\$93 each), add a Clark → Coron flight, start early after the Manila night out, cross more exposed water, and confirm seats.



Evidence score

43/50

Weighted: reviews and social count x3 · unweighted 23/30



Social x3



5/5 ticks: groups of about 15, 39% praise the group, mixed ages, 0% say quiet



Scenery



3 days through Culion and Linapacan, on the reviewed flagship route



Sleep



Nipa huts with bedding and nets; 2 of 49 reviews complain (4%)



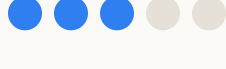
Logistics (safer)



3 flags: extra Clark to Coron flight (and the booked PPS flight is lost), an exposed crossing, seats unconfirmed



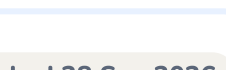
Review strength x3



Tripadvisor 4.9 from 1,317 reviews; Google 4.8 from ~2,097; Travelers' Choice 2026; route pages 5.00 (17) and 4.96 (27)



Value



~A\$950 midpoint scores 2, +1 because it is catered



The evidence

checked 28 Sep 2026



Tripadvisor



4.9

1,317 reviews

Travelers' Choice 2026. From a search snippet (the page blocks us)



Google Maps



4.8

~2,097 reviews

Operator-wide · 2026 reviews visible



Operator site



5.00

17 reviews

Coron → El Nido product (2017 to Nov 2024)



Operator site



4.96

27 reviews

El Nido → Coron product (2016 to Jan 2025)



We read **49 reviews**: all 44 on the operator's site plus the 5 that Google shows when you're not signed in. Only **7 of 49 (14%)** are from **2025–26**; Tripadvisor's recent reviews were blocked.



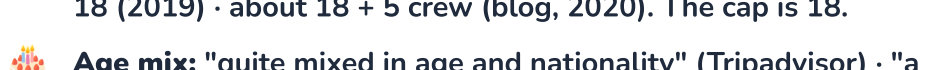
Praise the group, people or vibe



Say quiet, too young or too old



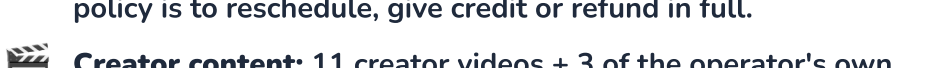
Praise the crew or guide



Sleep or facility complaints



Weather cancellations reported



Group size: 15 guests + 9 crew (Google, 2026) · 15 (Jan 2025) · 18 (2019) · about 18 + 5 crew (blog, 2020). The cap is 18.



Age mix: "quite mixed in age and nationality" (Tripadvisor) · "a mix of couples and adult families" (Google, 2026) · "several nationalities, diff ages" (2019).



Weather: no cancellations in the reviews. One 2018 trip swapped stops when they couldn't anchor. A 2020 blog mentions a choppy day and a skipped cliff jump. The operator's policy is to reschedule, give credit or refund in full.



Creator content: 11 creator videos + 3 of the operator's own on YouTube; the newest creator video is about 2 years old. TikTok @elnidoparadise: 42 videos, 166 followers. Instagram: login wall, not checked.

"There were 15 of us on the boat and 9 crew members."

Mónika D., Google Maps, ~5 months ago (≈Apr 2026) [↗](#)

"You bond so quickly with everyone on the boat because you spend three full days together."

Carmen, Google Maps, ~4 months ago (≈May 2026) [↗](#)

"Groups that are quite mixed in age and nationality... Other companies are ... very party-oriented, which is not the case here, although, no worries, the atmosphere is lively!"

Tripadvisor review (date not visible; from a search snippet) [↗](#)

"The tour guide and the team were very nice and helpful and the group was also pretty cool."

r/Philippines_Expats comment on El Nido Paradise (search snippet; date not shown) [↗](#)



See the real website





TRAVEL DAY · SUN 27 DEC

2

Option 2: the 27 Dec sleep-in plan

No early starts after the Poblacion night out · Makati → Clark → Busuanga → Coron town

~A\$704

for 2 (~A\$352 each)
+ A\$186 already lost



The day

SUN 27 DEC

~8:00am



Wake up (sleep-in after Poblacion)

Pack, check out

9:00am



Private car picks up in Makati

Prebooked · 2–2.5h + holiday traffic buffer

12:15pm



At Clark airport

Check-in closes 12:30pm (45 min before)

1:15pm



Cebgo flight Clark → Busuanga

2:40pm



Land at Busuanga

Pay ₱200 fee, shared van to town

~3:30pm



At the Coron town hotel

Evening free in town

MON 28 DEC

8:00am



At Coron Pier

El Nido Paradise boat leaves 9:00am



The plan, and if it goes wrong

Step	What to buy	Cost for 2	If it goes wrong
Makati → Clark	Prebooked private car, pickup ~9:00am Angeles City Taxi ₱5,000 incl. tolls	~ A\$114	The other company: ManilaAngelesTransfer ₱5,200 (12h notice). Grab is often declined on long trips
Clark → Busuanga	Cebgo 1:15pm → 2:40pm on Trip.com, A\$248 each + two prepaid 20kg bags (₱1,000 each, ~A\$23)	~ A\$542 A\$496 + A\$46 bags	PAL Express 2:15pm → 3:20pm, Trip.com A\$283 each (A\$566), 20kg bag included. Last flight of the day; PAL showed 4–5 seats left on 28 Sep
Airport → Coron town	Shared van ₱250 each + airport environmental fee ₱200 each cash	~ A\$21	Prebooked or private van
Night of 27 Dec	Hiraya Homestay , Coron town Booking.com 8.9 from 299 reviews	~ A\$27	Marbeth Inn (8.7 from 130, ~A\$28) or Divine Castle Travelers Inn (8.0 from 359, ~A\$22–24)
28 Dec start	Be at Coron Pier by 8:00am El Nido Paradise : departs 9:00; over 30 min late = no-show, 100% charge	—	See "If the whole day fails" below
Total for 2	~A\$352 each	~ A\$704	Plus A\$186 for 2 already lost on the 27 Dec Puerto Princesa flight



If the whole day fails

- **Move the boat trip to 30 or 31 Dec:** seats were open on 28 Sep. Change fee ₱3,500 (~A\$80); not possible within 48h of departure.
- **Or keep the Puerto Princesa flight** and do the trip in reverse: [El Nido](#) → [Coron](#) has seats on 28 and 29 Dec.



Why these two flights

- **Sunlight Air 11:45am** is the cheapest (A\$368 for 2), but it has a small fleet (3–4 ATRs) and a record of short-notice cancellations. Cebgo and PAL had no Clark → Busuanga cancellations in the Aug–Sep 2026 logs.
- **PAL Express 2:15pm** allows the longest sleep-in (~A\$728 total for 2), but it is the last flight, so there is no same-day backup.



All Clark → Busuanga nonstops, Sun 27 Dec

Early flights are shown for completeness; they don't fit the night out on 26 Dec.

Airline	Departs	Arrives	Google Flights (each)	Trip.com (A\$ each)
Cebgo	6:15am	7:40am	US\$132 ~A\$188	—
Sunlight Air	6:55am	8:10am	US\$134 ~A\$191	—
Cebgo	7:00am	8:25am	US\$152 ~A\$217	—
Cebgo	10:35am	12:00pm	US\$141 ~A\$201	—
PAL Express	11:25am	12:30pm	US\$163 ~A\$232	—
Sunlight Air	11:45am	1:00pm	US\$134 ~A\$191	A\$184
Cebgo The plan	1:15pm	2:40pm	US\$173 ~A\$247	A\$248
PAL Express Backup	2:15pm	3:20pm	US\$204 ~A\$291	A\$283

Prices one way per person, checked 28 Sep 2026 ([Google Flights](#) , Trip.com). — = not seen on Trip.com. US\$1 = A\$1.4258 and ₱1,000 = A\$22.83 ([open.er-api.com](#) , 28 Sep 2026). No nonstop Manila → Busuanga flights exist (all via Cebu).

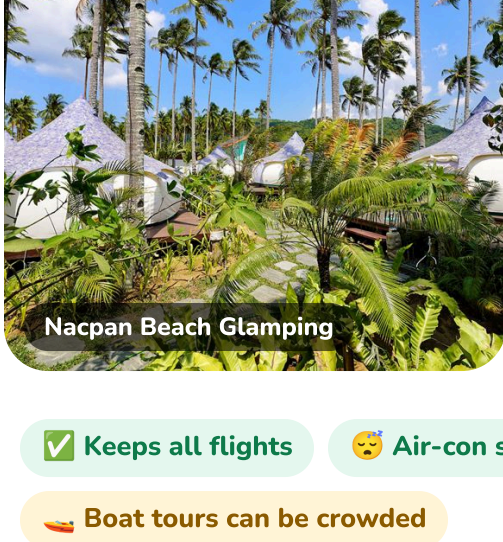
Busuanga airport is closed 6pm–6am, and the earliest 28 Dec arrival is 7:40am, too late for the boat, so **27 Dec is the only workable day**.

3

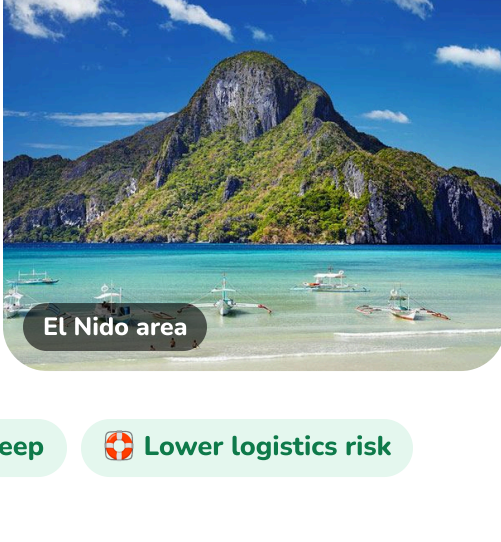
Stay in El Nido, land-based

Surf, a boat day, social hostels

~A\$450–700 A\$ per person, all in



Nacpan Beach Glamping



El Nido area

✓ Keeps all flights

😴 Air-con sleep

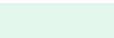
🚢 Lower logistics risk

🚤 Boat tours can be crowded

**Seats booked so far: Not applicable — land-based option (no shared trip seats)**

Online bookings only; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show.

27 SUN

**Land PPS, drive to El Nido**

Van or private car · arrive ~11pm

28 MON

**Nacpan surf lesson**

Nacpan Beach Glamping or Mad Monkey Nacpan

29 TUE

**Island-hopping day**

Tour A lagoons · shared or private

30 WED

**Outpost Beach Hostel**

Private ensuite · sunset social

31 THU

**Free morning**

Lio airport by 1:15pm

🇵🇭 Real beds every night: air-con glamping, then a private ensuite

🎉 Outpost: 57 events listed, 35% of reviews praise the vibe

🎂 But the hostel crowds skew young: 80% of Outpost reviewers are 30 or under

🧘 Flexible: change plans day by day

The catch: Trade-offs: less of an adventure, Tour A is crowded, and the hostel crowd is mostly in their 20s. Nacpan Glamping has air-con; Mad Monkey has no air-con and 0% of sampled reviewers were 31+.🔍 **Evidence score**

38/50

Weighted: reviews and social count x3 · unweighted 24/30

**Social** x3

3/5 ticks (Outpost night): events + 35% praise the vibe; but no shared group, and only 20% of reviewers are 31+

**Scenery**

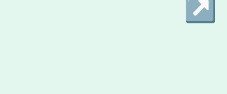
One Tour A day on the busy lagoon circuit + Nacpan beach

**Sleep**

Nacpan Glamping air-con praised in 8 of 30 reviews; Outpost private ensuite

**Logistics (safer)**

0 flags: flights kept, no open-water crossing, day-by-day flexibility

**Review strength** x3

Each stay has 1,000+ reviews, but the weighted averages are 4.59–4.65 (below the 4.7 needed for 5)

**Value**

~A\$575 midpoint; meals not included



The evidence

checked 28 Sep 2026



Nacpan Beach Glamping

Night 1 · air-con option



Booking.com



8.9

702 reviews



Google



4.6

700 reviews



Tripadvisor



4.8

634 reviews

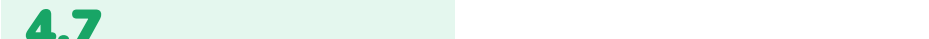
As shown on Google



Latest 30 Booking.com reviews (18 May to 8 Sep 2026; all from 2026): 47% couples, 23% solo, 20% groups, 10% families.



Praise the air-con



Thin walls or noise



Mention a social vibe



Scored below 7/10



“Huge, aircon tents with comfy mattresses ... with 35 degrees outside!”

Booking.com, 23 May 2026

“Tent walls are basically just fabric ... if you are a really light sleeper ... bring some earplugs.”

Emily (Australia), Booking.com, 3 Aug 2026



Mad Monkey Nacpan

Night 1 · alternative



Hostelworld



9.4

1,856 reviews



Google



4.4

1,352 reviews



Tripadvisor



4.7

516 reviews

As shown on Google



Latest 30 Hostelworld reviews (May to Aug 2026, the wet low season). Reviewer ages: 18–24: 57% · 25–30: 43% · 31+: 0%.



Praise the vibe or events



Say quiet or dead (low season)



No-air-con complaints



Mention bad weather



“If it had AC it would be the nest [best] hostel I would have stayed in on my trip so far.”

Male 25–30 (Australia), Hostelworld, Jun 2026

“Really quiet right now. But apart from that was great.”

Female 18–24, Hostelworld, Jul 2026



Outpost Beach Hostel

Night 3 · the social night



Hostelworld



9.5

3,075 reviews

Atmosphere 9.8



Booking.com



8.6

484 reviews



Google



4.5

683 reviews



Tripadvisor



4.5

201 reviews

As shown on Google



Latest 30 Hostelworld reviews (Jun to Sep 2026) + latest 30 Booking.com reviews (May to Sep 2026; 73% solo travellers). Hostelworld has 57 events listed: karaoke, game night, beer pong, beach party.



Praise the vibe, people or events



Say it's too young for 30-somethings



Noise complaints (music, construction)



Praise the staff



“They had a pool party, trivia and karaoke.”

Female 31–40 (USA), Hostelworld, Aug 2026

“The average age is veryyyy young, think late teens to early 20s ... if you are looking for a more mature hostel (late 20s–early to mid 30s) this is not the vibe.”

Solo traveller, Booking.com, 24 Jun 2026



El Nido Tour A (day trip)

Day 3



GetYourGuide



4.5

7 reviews

One listing (2025–26). Dozens of agencies sell Tour A, so there is no single review base.



YouTube

8

of top 20 results

Tour A videos with up to 1.1M views

Crowding is the common complaint about Tour A on Reddit and travel blogs.

“On the El Nido tour some stops we couldn't even make because there wasn't enough boat parking. It felt a little instagram vs reality.”

r/Philippines_Expats comment (search snippet; date not shown)

See the real website

Outpost Beach Hostel

NEW NEW OPERATOR

A

Yohak Linapacan return trip

From El Nido · 2 nights glamping at Parada Beach Camp

~A\$900–950 A\$ per person, all in



Parada Beach Camp · Yohak



Glamping tent · Yohak



Yohak boat

✓ Keeps all flights

🛏 Glamping: beds, fans, pool

NEW Launched April 2026

🌊 Rougher sea in Dec



Seats booked so far: 2 of 18 booked online · needs 4 to run

Online bookings only; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show.

27 SUN



Land PPS, van to El Nido

Arrive late

28 MON



Meet 7:30am at Lio

Boat to Linapacan · Parada night 1

29 TUE



Parada Beach Camp

Glamping night 2

30 WED



Back to El Nido

31 THU



Free morning

Lio airport by 1:15pm

💰 ₱28,000 (~A\$626) + private tent ~A\$89 + fees ~A\$25

★ Camp: 9.5/10 from 114 Booking.com reviews. Yohak itself: 0 reviews

👤 One-person business, needs 4 guests to run



The catch: brand-new one-person business with no independent reviews, needs 4 guests to run, and a rougher sea on that side in December (Yohak itself says March to May is best).



Evidence score

22/50

Weighted: reviews and social count x3 · unweighted 16/30



Social x3



3 ticks (shared boat, evening events, no "quiet" complaints) –1 because only 2 of 18 seats were booked



Scenery



Linapacan waters, but only 2 boat days (out and back)



Sleep



Glamping tents with fans from 9pm to 6am; heat mentioned in 2 of 30 reviews (7%)



Logistics (safer)



3 flags: operator launched April 2026, exposed east-side crossing, below the 4-guest minimum



Review strength x3



Yohak has 0 reviews on Google and none elsewhere (Parada camp on its own would score 3)



Value



~A\$925 midpoint scores 2, +1 because it is catered



The evidence

checked 28 Sep 2026



Yohak on Google



0

reviews

Listing exists, no rating yet



Yohak website



2

testimonials

Undated. One says: "This might be their first review"



Parada · Booking



9.5

114 reviews

Up from 9.4/77 on our last check



Parada · Google



4.3

25 reviews

Tripadvisor listings shown there: 3.7 (3) and 3.0 (2)



Parada · Hostelworld



9.3

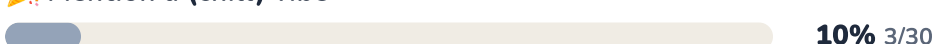
2 reviews



Latest 30 Parada reviews on Booking.com (10 Jan to 16 May 2026): **77% couples**, 13% groups, 10% solo. There were no new Booking.com reviews after 16 May.



Mention a (chill) vibe



Tents hot by day (fan OK at night)



"We were the only ones there"



Praise the staff or hosts



Creator content: 0 YouTube videos for Yohak or Parada. TikTok and Instagram: not found.



Weather: Yohak's own Linapacan page says the best time is "March to May (crucial for calm crossings)".

"We were a little nervous booking Yohak since they were brand new and didn't have any reviews yet."

Testimonial on the Yohak website (undated) [↗](#)

"We were the only ones there so had the whole place for ourself ... Take a book (or 2) with you here because there is little to do."

Couple, Booking.com (Parada), 20 Jan 2026 [↗](#)

"The tents are comfortable, but can get very hot during the day."

Conor D., Google Maps (Parada), ~1 year ago [↗](#)



See the real website





How we scored

Six metrics, each from 1 to 5 dots, with the same thresholds for every option. Every number was checked on 28 Sep 2026.

 **The weighting (your top two criteria count x3)**

 **Review strength x3**

 **Social x3**

 **Scenery x1**

 **Sleep x1**

 **Logistics x1**

 **Value x1**

Weighted score = $\sum$ (dots $\times$ weight), out of 50. Proven reviews + a proven social group = 30 of the 50 points. The unweighted /30 total is shown too.

1 · Collect



Ratings and counts from Tripadvisor, Google Maps, Booking.com, Hostelworld, GetYourGuide and the operators' own sites.

2 · Sample



The latest 30–60 reviews for each place (49 for the boat operator), coded for social, sleep, crew and weather.

3 · Apply the key



Thresholds below, then weight them. Proxy data is shown but never scored.

Metric	Weight	    	    	    	    	    
		1	2	3	4	5
 Social Checklist: 1 point for each tick (minimum score 1). Only reviews of this exact trip or stay count. - Shared group: the same people for the days (not just a hostel) - Nightly group events (bonfire, socials, games) ≥30% of sampled reviews praise the group, people or vibe - Age fit: ≥25% of reviewers aged 31+, or reviewers describe a mixed-age crowd <10% of sampled reviews say quiet, dead or too young –1 if fewer than 4 people are booked when last checked	x3	0–1 points	2 points	3 points	4 points	5 points
 Scenery What you actually see, based on the route.	x1	Mostly transit	Beach or land only, no boat days	1 boat day on the busy El Nido circuit + beach days	2–3 days in remote waters, but the route is new or has fewer boat days	3 days at sea through Linapacan/Culion with remote camps, on a route past guests have reviewed
 Sleep Bed quality and heat. December nights are about 24–27°C.	x1	No bedding, or no data	Shared beach tents with mats, or dorms; or heat/noise complaints ≥15%	Beach nipa huts with bedding and nets, no air-con; complaints <10%	Private glamping tent or room with fans; heat complaints <15%	Private air-con room or tent, and reviews praise the air-con
 Logistics risk More dots = safer. Start at 5 and lose 1 for each red flag: ① new or unreviewed operator/route ② needs an extra flight or gives up a booked one ③ open-water crossing exposed to the December north-east monsoon (amihan) ④ seats or minimum numbers unconfirmed ⑤ less than 18 hours before a flight.	x1	4+ flags	3 flags	2 flags	1 flag	0 flags
 Review strength Across platforms; /10 scores are halved to /5. A score of 4+ needs reviews from the last 12 months. If the exact trip has no reviews it scores 1: operator-wide reviews are shown but not counted.	x3	<10 reviews	10–49 reviews, or average <4.2	50+ reviews averaging ≥4.2	200+ reviews averaging ≥4.5	1,000+ reviews averaging ≥4.7 on 2+ platforms
 Value Midpoint of the all-in A\$ per person (tour, transfers, rooms, flight changes). +1 if at least 2 days are fully catered (meals and drinks included). Maximum 5.	x1	over A\$1,050	A\$901–1,050	A\$751–900	A\$551–750	A\$550 or less

Only evidence about the exact trip or stay counts. Proxy data (for example, El Nido Paradise's Coron route for the new Port Barton route) is shown in the evidence panels, clearly labelled PROXY, but it is never scored. The review samples are the latest reviews we could reach on each platform, coded by keyword and then checked by hand. Only English keywords were matched, so a few reviews in other languages may be undercounted.



Side by side

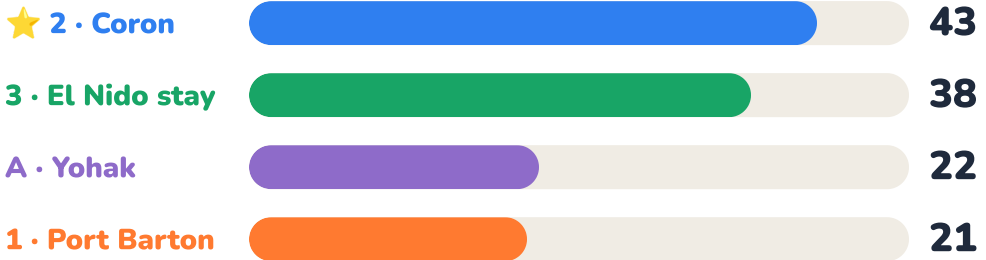
Green = 4–5 dots, yellow = 3, red = 1–2. The small print is the key number behind each score.

	1 Port Barton	★ 2 Coron	3 El Nido stay	A Yohak
✈ Flights kept	✓ All	✗ Drop PPS flight lose ~A\$93 each	✓ All	✓ All
💰 A\$ each	~700–750	~850–1,050	~450–700	~900–950
🛋 Seats booked so far	2 of 18 booked online	13 of 32 booked online	N/A land-based option	2 of 18 booked online · needs 4 to run
🎉 Social x3	● ○ ○ ○ ○ unproven: 0 reviews	● ● ● ● ● ~15 guests, 39% praise	● ● ● ○ ○ 20% of reviewers 31+	● ● ○ ○ ○ 2 of 18 booked
🌴 Scenery	● ● ● ● ○ new route	● ● ● ● ● Linapacan + Culion	● ● ● ○ ○ busy Tour A	● ● ● ● ○ 2 boat days
😴 Sleep	● ● ○ ○ ○ tents	● ● ● ○ ○ nipa huts	● ● ● ● ● air-con, ensuite	● ● ● ● ○ glamping, fans
🚢 Logistics (safer)	● ● ● ● ○ 1 flag: new route	● ● ○ ○ ○ 3 flags	● ● ● ● ● 0 flags	● ● ○ ○ ○ 3 flags
★ Review strength x3	● ○ ○ ○ ○ 0 route reviews	● ● ● ● ● Tripadvisor 4.9/1,317 · Google 4.8/~2,097	● ● ● ● ○ 1,000+ each, 4.6	● ○ ○ ○ ○ Yohak: 0
💰 Value	● ● ● ● ● ~A\$725, catered	● ● ● ○ ○ ~A\$950, catered	● ● ● ● ○ ~A\$575	● ● ● ○ ○ ~A\$925, catered
📝 Weighted /50	21	43	38	22
Unweighted /30	17	23	24	16

🛋 **Booking note:** Online bookings only; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show. El Nido Paradise El Nido to Coron 28 Dec has 2 of 32 booked, but it ends in Coron, so they would need the 6am 31 Dec ferry back; it is outside the shared itinerary.



Evidence score summary



Weighted evidence score out of 50 (reviews and social x3)

Option 1 · Port Barton → El Nido: 21/50. It keeps the booked flights and follows a new three-day west-coast route; the route has 0 reviews and the group is unproven.

Option 2 · Coron → El Nido: 43/50. It uses the reviewed flagship route with Tripadvisor 4.9 from 1,317 reviews; Google 4.8 from ~2,097; Travelers' Choice 2026, plus sampled groups of about 15. It gives up the booked PPS flight, adds a Clark → Coron flight, and has a more exposed crossing.

Option 3 · Stay in El Nido: 38/50. It keeps the flights, uses land-based stays and a day boat, and has no open-water crossing. The social side is hostel-based and skews young (only 20% of Outpost reviewers are 31+).

Option A · Yohak Linapacan return: 22/50. It includes glamping and two boat days, but the operator is new, has no independent reviews, needs 4 guests to run, and faces a rougher December crossing.



What we need to decide

1



Discuss the options with SJ

Compare the routes, evidence, seats and trade-offs. Option 3 is the land-based alternative.

2



WhatsApp El Nido Paradise

Ask El Nido Paradise on WhatsApp (+63 949 132 8952) how many are booked on 28 Dec, the usual age range, and whether each person can have their own hut. Then confirm the Coron seats and the Clark → Coron flight fare; WhatsApp or agent bookings may not show online.

3



Then book

Tour deposit (30%), the Coron flight and a Coron hotel for 27 Dec. For option 3 instead: a van from Puerto Princesa.



What we couldn't verify:

- Any reviews of the new Port Barton route (it launches Oct 2026). It is scored on its own (lack of) evidence; the Coron-route proxy is shown, not scored.
- Tripadvisor pages (blocked to us): the counts shown come from search snippets and Google's "reviews from the web" panel, and we couldn't sample recent Tripadvisor reviews.
- Reddit (blocked): we only saw search-engine snippets of threads, not full threads or dates.
- Instagram (login wall) and TikTok hashtag counts (not shown when logged out). Google only shows 5 reviews when you're not signed in.
- Group size and ages on our actual dates, Trip.com fares for Clark → Coron (Google Flights fares are shown; Trip.com is still being checked), and New Year hotel prices.

"~" means an estimate. Peso prices converted at about ₱1 = A\$0.0224. Map pins marked approximate are close, not exact. Map © OpenStreetMap contributors. Raw review captures are saved in the research folder.